

doc-sola-fide

Affirms · Soteriology › Five Solas · doctrine · unanimous_lineages · confidence: medium

Statement under examination

A sinner is justified before God by faith in Christ apart from works of the law as a ground of justification; works are the fruit, not the basis, of justification.

Rationale

Paul's lexical pattern at Rom 3:28, Gal 2:16, Gal 3:11, Phil 3:9, and Eph 2:8-9 places *dikaioo* (G1344) through *pistis* (G4102) and apart from *erga nomou* (G2041/G3551) as the instrumental ground of right standing; *logizomai* (G3049) at Rom 4:3-5 frames the reckoning as gift, not wages. James 2:24 uses *dikaioo* in a demonstrative sense (faith proven by works), not as a contradicting ground.

Reasoning

Verdict: Scripture teaches that a person is set right with God on the basis of trust in Christ, not on the basis of keeping the law's requirements. The strongest reason for this is Paul. In Romans 3:28 he writes that a person is justified by faith apart from works of the law. In Romans 4:3-5 he says Abraham believed God and it was credited to him as righteousness, and that to the one who does not work but trusts the God who justifies the ungodly, faith is counted as righteousness. Ephesians 2:8-9 puts it most directly. By grace you have been saved through faith, and this is not your own doing, it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast. Philippians 3:9 contrasts a righteousness of one's own from the law with the righteousness from God that depends on faith. The strongest complicating text is James 2:14-26. James asks whether a faith without works can save, says faith without works is dead, points to Abraham being justified by works when he offered Isaac, and says explicitly that a person is justified by works and not by faith only. The same Greek word for justified is used by both Paul and James. The tension is real at the surface and was felt strongly in church history. The most careful handling reads Paul and James as addressing different questions with the same word. Paul asks how a guilty sinner first receives right standing before God, and answers by faith, since works of the law cannot earn it. James asks how a claim to have faith is shown to be true and not empty, and answers by works, since a faith that produces no obedience is dead. On this reading Abraham was reckoned righteous in Genesis 15:6 when he believed (Paul's point) and was vindicated as a man of true faith decades later when he offered Isaac in Genesis 22 (James's point). The verdict therefore stands. Salvation is by grace through faith and not by works as the basis, but a living faith will inevitably produce works, and a faith that produces no works is not living faith at all.

Denominational landscape

Christian lineages broadly agree that salvation is by grace through faith and not by human merit, but they disagree sharply on the word alone and on what works contribute after the initial reception of grace. Lutherans and Reformed and most Anglicans and classical Methodists confess justification by faith alone as a central article of the Reformation. The Augsburg Confession article four and the Anglican Article 11 and the Methodist Article 9 all state that we are accounted righteous before God only for the merit of Christ by faith and not for our own works. The Roman Catholic Church teaches that justification comes from the grace of God as free and undeserved help, but rejects the Reformation slogan alone in the sense of excluding cooperation with grace. The Council of Trent in 1547 anathematized those who teach faith alone in a sense that requires no other cooperation. The 1999 Joint Declaration between Catholics and

Lutherans reached a qualified shared statement that the sinner is justified by faith and through the grace of Christ, while both sides kept their distinct emphases. Eastern Orthodox lineages reject the term sola fide as a Western legal framing and prefer to speak of salvation as a lifelong synergy of grace and human response, with theosis as the goal. Pentecostal and most Baptist and Plymouth Brethren bodies affirm the Reformation position. Public-record cults that deny grace-through-faith and demand a works-based requirement for salvation include the Latter-day Saints (faith plus ordinances plus continued worthiness) and various legalistic groups (Iglesia ni Cristo's exclusive-church requirement, certain Branhamite teachings). The core grace-through-faith pattern is held across historic Christianity; the precise word alone is contested between Reformation heirs on one side and Rome and the East on the other.

Position thresholds

Would die for if challenged	No
Cult marker if denied	No
Would visit if otherwise	Yes
Would participate if otherwise	Yes
Would serve if otherwise	No
Would be member if otherwise	No
Would let children be taught otherwise	No
Would marry if held otherwise	No
Would publicly correct if otherwise	Yes

Notes

Core grace-through-faith pattern is canonical and pan-Pauline. The 'alone' qualifier carries Reformation-confessional specificity that James 2:24 explicitly addresses by name (faith ou monon, not alone) using dikaios in a vindictory/demonstrative sense. Catholic and Orthodox lineages affirm justification by grace through faith while rejecting the Reformed 'alone' as worded; they emphasize cooperation with grace and works as fruit-but-not-mere-fruit. The doctrine clears canonical demonstration of the substance (grace-through-faith, not by works of the law) but the precise Reformed mechanism remains an in-house Christian dispute, not a gospel-denial boundary.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: **yes**

Neutralized form. A sinner is reckoned righteous before God on the basis of faith in Christ rather than on the basis of works of the law; what role works play in or after justification is the point under examination.

Notes. The original statement uses Reformed-confessional vocabulary (ground of justification, fruit not basis) that assumes the Reformed answer to the very question James 2 reopens. Worked the neutralized form.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, new_perspective_on_paul, synergistic_orthodoxy, tridentine_catholic

analogia scripturae invoked

Competing lens verdicts

covenant_theology_and_reformation · affirms sola fide as worded; dikaioo is forensic-declarative; Paul and James use dikaioo in two senses:

new_perspective_on_paul · complicates; works of the law refers primarily to Jewish boundary markers (circumcision, food laws, sabbaths), reframing what sola fide excludes:

synergistic_orthodox_and_catholic · affirms by grace through faith; denies alone as worded; reads James 2:24 as integral, not subordinate, to Pauline justification:

tridentine_catholic · denies sola fide as worded; affirms grace-initiated cooperation; canon 9 of Trent Session 6 anathematizes faith alone in a sense that excludes cooperation:

The verbal harmonization of Paul and James turns on whether dikaioo carries the same lexical sense in both. Paul's accounting-language (logizomai) and contrast with works of the law point to a forensic declaration. James's flow (faith proves itself by works, Abraham vindicated by offering Isaac decades after Gen 15:6) reads naturally as demonstrative justification. The Reformation slogan as worded carries this exegetical commitment; the substance (grace-through-faith, not by works of the law) is canonically demonstrable on a wider lexical base.

Scripture (apparatus + interlinear)

Rom.3.28 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. δικαιοῦσθαι (dikaiousthai) G1344, πίστει (pistei) G4102, ἔργων νόμου (ergon nomou) G2041/G3551

Force. Paul reckons that a person is justified by faith apart from works of the law; instrumental dative pistei contrasts with the excluded ground works of the law.

Rom.4.3 · **for** · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key term. ἐπίστευσεν (episteusen) G4100, ἐλογίσθη (elogisthe) G3049, δικαιοσύνην (dikaiosynen) G1343

Force. Abraham believed and it was reckoned to him as righteousness; logizomai is an accounting term for crediting to one's ledger.

Rom.4.4-5 · **for** · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key term. λογίζεται (logizetai) G3049, χάριν (charin) G5485, ὀφείλημα (opheilema) G3783

Force. To the worker, wages are not credited as a gift but as a debt; to the one who does not work but believes, faith is credited as righteousness.

Gal.2.16 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. δικαιοῦται (dikaioutai) G1344, πίστεως Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ (pisteos Iesou Christou) G4102

Force. A person is not justified by works of the law but through faith in Jesus Christ; the genitive permits objective (faith in) or subjective (faithfulness of) readings, both excluding works of the law as ground.

Gal.3.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. δικαιούται (dikaioutai) G1344, νόμῳ (nomo) G3551, πίστεως (pisteos) G4102

Force. No one is justified before God by the law, for the righteous shall live by faith (citing Hab 2:4).

Eph.2.8-9 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. χάριτι (chariti) G5485, σεσωσμένοι (sesosmenoi) G4982, πίστεως (pisteos) G4102, δῶρον (doron) G1435

Force. By grace you have been saved through faith; this is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast.

Phil.3.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. δικαιοσύνην (dikaiosynen) G1343, νόμου (nomou) G3551, πίστεως (pisteos) G4102

Force. Not a righteousness from law but the righteousness from God that depends on faith.

Tit.3.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ἔργων (ergon) G2041, ἔλεος (eleos) G1656, ἔσωσεν (esosen) G4982, παλιγγενεσίας (palingenesias) G3824

Force. He saved us not because of works done by us in righteousness but according to his own mercy; works excluded as ground.

Gen.15.6 · for · genre: narrative

Key term. ἀμὴν (aman) H539, חַשָּׁב (chashav) H2803, תְּשַׁדָּקָה (tsedaqah) H6666

Force. Abram believed Yahweh and he reckoned it to him as righteousness; the Hebrew lexical pattern that Paul cites in Rom 4 and Gal 3.

Hab.2.4 · for · genre: prophecy

Key term. צַדִּיק (tsaddiq) H6662, אֱמוּנָה (emunah) H530, יָחִיד (yichyeh) H2421

Force. The righteous shall live by his faith/faithfulness; load-bearing Hebrew text cited by Paul at Rom 1:17, Gal 3:11, and Heb 10:38.

Jas.2.24 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. δικαιούται (dikaioutai) G1344, ἔργων (ergon) G2041, πίστεως (pisteos) G4102, μόνον (monon) G3440

Force. A person is justified by works and not by faith alone; the same verb dikaiōo as Paul, but in a demonstrative/vindictory sense (shown to be righteous), exemplified by Abraham offering Isaac after Gen 15:6.

Jas.2.17 · complicates · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key term. πίστις (pistis) G4102, ἔργα (erga) G2041, νεκρά (nekra) G3498

Force. Faith by itself if it does not have works is dead; complicates only the empty profession reading of sola fide, not the gift-of-grace ground.

Rom.2.13 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. δικαιωθήσονται (dikaiōthesontai) G1344, ποιηταί (poietai) G4163, νόμου (nomou) G3551

Force. Not the hearers of the law but the doers will be justified; appears to qualify Rom 3:28, generally read as eschatological vindication contingent on the same faith-wrought obedience.

Rom.3.20 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. δικαιωθήσεται (dikaiothesetai) G1344, ἔργων νόμου (ergon nomou) G2041/G3551

Force. By works of the law no flesh will be justified in his sight; the negative twin of Rom 3:28.

Rom.5.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. δικαιωθέντες (dikaiothentes) G1344, πίστεως (pisteos) G4102, εἰρήνην (eirenen) G1515

Force. Having been justified by faith, we have peace with God; aorist participle treats the justification as a settled completed event grounded in faith.

Acts.13.39 · for · genre: narrative

Key term. δικαιούται (dikaioutai) G1344, πιστεύων (pisteuon) G4100

Force. Everyone who believes is justified from everything from which you could not be justified by the law of Moses; Paul's preaching at Pisidian Antioch ties faith to release from law as ground.

Luk.18.14 · for · genre: parable · figures: parable

Key term. δεδικαιωμένος (dedikaiomenos) G1344

Force. The tax collector went down to his house justified rather than the Pharisee; Jesus pictures justification on the basis of a self-emptying cry for mercy, not Torah-keeping.

Concordance lemmas traversed

G1344, G1343, G4102, G4100, G3049, G2041, G3551, G5485, G1435, G4982, G3440, G3498, G1656, G3824, G4163, H539, H2803, H6666, H530, H6662, H2421

complicating texts searched: Yes

Counter-witness traditions

lutheran · Augsburg Confession Article IV,

<https://bookofconcord.org/augsburg-confession/> · **affirms · verified**

“are freely justified for Christ's sake, through faith, when they believe that they are received into favor”

methodist · United Methodist Articles of Religion, Article IX,

<https://www.umc.org/en/content/articles-of-religion> · **affirms · verified**

“We are accounted righteous before God only for the merit of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ, by faith, and not for our own works or deservings”

catholic_magisterial · Catechism of the Catholic Church on grace and justification (CCC 1996), via vatican.va · complicates · verified

“Our justification comes from the grace of God. Grace is favor, the free and undeserved help that God gives us to respond to his call”

anglican · Thirty-Nine Articles, Article XI Of the Justification of Man (historic public text) · affirms · unverified

“We are accounted righteous before God only for the merit of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ by faith, and not for our own works or deservings”

reformed · Westminster Confession of Faith, Chapter 11 On Justification · affirms · unverified

“Faith, thus receiving and resting on Christ and His righteousness, is the alone instrument of justification”

eastern_orthodox · Orthodox Church in America doctrinal materials, oca.org;
representative Orthodox theological position · **complicates** · **unverified**

“Salvation is by grace, received through faith, and worked out in a lifelong synergy with God's grace; the Western legal framing of sola fide is not the Orthodox framework”

catholic_magisterial · Council of Trent, Session 6, Canon 9 (1547) · **denies** · **unverified**

“If anyone says that by faith alone the sinner is justified, so as to mean that nothing else is required to cooperate, let him be anathema”

Web sources

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/romans/3-28.htm>

“dikaiousythai G1344 present passive infinitive 'to be justified'; pistei G4102 instrumental dative 'by faith'; ergon nomou G2041/G3551 'works of law' excluded”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/galatians/2-16.htm>

“pisteos Iesou Christou genitive permits both objective ('faith in') and subjective ('faithfulness of') readings; both exclude works of law as ground”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/ephesians/2-8.htm>

“chariti G5485 dative 'by grace', sesosmenoi G4982 perfect passive 'have been saved', pisteos G4102 'through faith', doron G1435 'gift’”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/romans/4-3.htm>

“elogisthe G3049 aorist passive 'was reckoned/credited'; accounting metaphor of faith placed on the ledger as righteousness”

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/james/2-24.htm>

“dikaioantai G1344 with monon G3440 'a person is justified by works and not by faith alone'; demonstrative/vindicatory sense in context”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://bookofconcord.org/augsburg-confession/>

“freely justified for Christ's sake, through faith, when they believe that they are received into favor”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://www.umc.org/en/content/articles-of-religion>

“accounted righteous before God only for the merit of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ, by faith, and not for our own works or deservings”

Flags

- stem-pre-loaded-verdict
- confession-tradition-divergence
- apparatus-vs-counter-witness-conflict